quarters in the city to within the palace grounds, sent them food from his own table, and went to visit their chapel, at Easter, once they had settled in. When Akbar saw the images of Jesus and Mary, ‘he first, in Muhammadan fashion, made a profound reverence before it’. Akbar then took off his turban and shook out his long hair, grown back after the mystic episode of 1577, and, to the delight of the Jesuits, ‘like a Christian… with clasped hands, bent his knee’. Lastly, he prostrated himself in the manner of Hindus saying that ‘God deserved the homage of all peoples’. A few days later Akbar arrived with his three sons and some of his noblemen and they all respectfully bowed down before the Christian images. Akbar accepted ‘with the greatest delight’ a painting of the Virgin, brought from Rome. This was possibly a copy of the Byzantine Virgin, a miraculous painting deemed to have been painted by St Luke himself, which can be seen today in the Borghese Chapel in Rome. Akbar appointed Abu’l Fazl, who the Jesuits decreed was a ‘young man of a keen and capable mind’, to help the priests learn Persian and he taught Acquaviva the Persian language within three months. Acquaviva began translating the gospel into Persian and the first reader of these translated texts was Abu’l Fazl himself, who was delighted with them. These two men, Acquaviva and Abu’l Fazl, could not have been more different—one ravaged and skeletal in his austere, bleak robes the other already plump in the gold-limned, perfumed qaba of an exquisitely dressed Mughal courtier. One with his single, tenacious, and driven spirituality and the other with his capacious, adaptable, and inclusive mind.

Akbar seemed to have been most impressed with the priests’ vows of poverty and chastity, for they refused all the presents and money he tried to give them. ‘He could well understand,’ said Monserrate, ‘that a man was especially dear to God who abjured the pleasures of the world, wife, children and possessions.’ Indeed the question of his many wives appeared to be a sensitive topic for Akbar, for when Acquaviva, with considerable lack of tact, informed Akbar that apart from the first wife, ‘the rest are all courtesans and adulteresses, whom the commandment of God and Christ it is wickedness to retain’, Akbar replied with uncharacteristic sharpness that ‘these things are in the hand of God, who grants to those who ask plain paths from which they cannot stray. I myself have no desires’, he continued evasively and clearly disingenuously, ‘I reckon wives, children, empires, as of no account’.